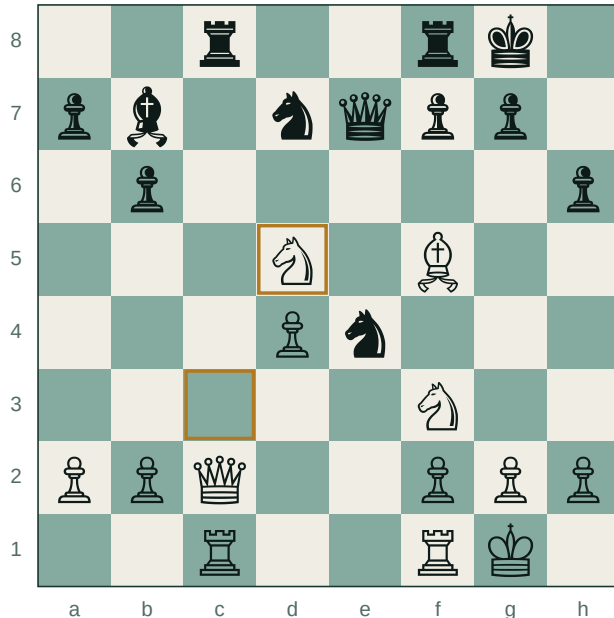


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 16

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 16.Nxd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

16...Bxd5 17. Qxc8 Rxc8 18. Rxc8+ Nf8

16...Bxd5 The bishop captures the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **17.Qxc8**.

17...Rxc8 The rook captures the queen on c8. Recorded reply: **18.Rxc8+**.

18...Nf8 The knight moves from d7 to f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from -1 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on f5 and knight on d5. Check for tactical protection.